# SSUNS PARLIAMENTARY PROCEDURE

## PART I – GENERAL RULES

### 1. Scope

These rules shall apply to all regular sessions of the Secondary Schools' United Nations Symposium for all committees. These rules are self-sufficient and no other rules shall apply, unless otherwise stated in the supplemental rules for an individual committee. In situations not covered by the rules, the Chair shall constitute the final authority.

### 2. Language

The working language of the conference is English, unless otherwise specified. All documents must be drawn up and speeches delivered in English, unless otherwise specified. No translation services will be provided in any committee.

### 3. The Secretariat

The Secretariat shall consist of the Secretary-General and those persons the Secretary-General has appointed to the Secretariat. Any member of the Secretariat may address any committee at any time. The ruling of a Secretariat member on any rule or regulation herein is final and overrides any other ruling or appeal. Any rule may be altered, suspended or added by a member of the Secretariat at any time.

## PART II – THE DAIS

### 4. Composition

Each committee shall have a Dais, composed of several staff members, as designated by the Secretariat. Individually or collectively, the Dais shall have the capacity to assume the office of the Chair. This status shall be transferable to other committee officers.

**5. Duties**

The Dais shall be responsible for maintaining the Speakers' List, recording the Roll Call at the beginning of each committee session, and recording the results of all votes in the committee.

The Chair shall declare the opening and closing of each meeting, direct discussion, accord the right to speak, equitably and objectively recognize points and motions, put questions to a vote, announce decisions, ensure the observation of these rules and rule on disputed points.

The Chair is also primarily responsible for the substantive content of the committee proceedings. The Chair and his or her designates may authorize draft resolutions for their introduction to the floor.

**6. Powers**

After the Secretariat, the Chair shall be the final authority in each committee. The Chair may refuse to entertain any procedural motion at her/his discretion. At any time, the Chair may propose the adoption of a procedural motion without a vote by the committee.

**7. Competence**

The members of the committee may not question the competence of the Dais. The Undersecretary-General of Committee Affairs, with the advice and consent of the Secretary-General, may remove any member of the Dais if necessary. The committee members may approach the Secretariat if they so desire.

PART III – DELEGATIONS

**8. Rights**

Each state or character shall be represented by one voting delegate on each committee, unless otherwise stated.

**9. Non-Member States / Observer States**

A representative of a state that is not a member of the United Nations, or a representative of an organization holding observer status, shall have the same rights as a full member except that he or she may not vote on substantive matters and may not be a sponsor or signatory to a resolution.

**10. Non-Governmental Organizations**

A representative of a non-governmental organization shall have the same rights as a full member except that he or she may not vote on substantive matters and may be neither a sponsor nor a signatory to resolutions. Delegates representing a non-governmental organization will have access to certain unique procedural actions:

Oral Statements to Committee: An NGO may submit a written appeal to the Chair explaining the topic and intention of the proposed statement. The Chair will then, at his or her discretion, interrupt the normal flow of debate to introduce the NGO. Circulation of written pronouncements: An NGO may submit to the Chair a written pronouncement of no more than 1000 words, addressing the position and work of his or her organization. This pronouncement will then, at the discretion of the Chair, be distributed throughout the committee.

**17. Speakers' List**

**At SSUNS, we don't set a single topic for debate. Instead, delegates are expected to debate all sub-topics simultaneously, so that discussion isn't constrained to just one part of the research and can draw on all of it at once. Because of this, debate begins directly with a secondary speakers list, skipping the primary list altogether.**

*Secondary Speakers' List*
Once the first agenda topic is set, a secondary speakers' list dealing with the topic in question shall be opened. Separate lists shall be established for specific procedural motions on an as-needed basis.

*General Policy*
A member may add his or her name to the list, provided it is not already on the list, by submitting a written request to the Dais. Debate on a topic is closed automatically upon exhaustion of the secondary speakers' list.

**18. Suspension of Debate**

During the course of debate, a delegate may move to caucus. When making such a motion, the delegate must specify a type, time limit, purpose and, in the case of a moderated caucus, a speaking time for the caucus. There are two types of caucus:

Unmoderated caucus: The Dais is not involved. Delegates may leave their seats and/or the committee room to speak to each other in a less formal setting or to write draft resolutions. No points or motions shall be in order during unmoderated caucus.
Moderated caucus: Delegates are recognized, at the Chair's discretion, for a specified amount of speaking time. During a moderated caucus, the Chair shall call to order delegates who are making speeches not germane to the designated topic. No points or motions shall be in order during a moderated caucus except Points of Order, Points of Personal Privilege and Rights of Reply. Delegates may not yield speaking time during a moderated caucus.
PART IV – THE COMMITTEE
12. Roll Call

At the beginning of each session the Dais shall initiate roll call. Each delegate representing a UN member state must respond either "present" or "present and voting." Delegates who are "present" may vote in favour, opposed or abstain on substantive matters, subject to the rules on abstention. Delegates who are

“present and voting” may only vote in favour or opposed; abstentions are never permitted. Delegates representing non-member states/observer states or non-governmental organizations may only be “present,” as they cannot vote on substantive matters.

Abstentions are only permitted on questions regarding substantive matters, by delegates representing a UN member state who responded “present” during roll call. If a delegation is not present at the time the roll call is taken, the delegate is expected to pass a note to the Dais stating his or her voting status once he or she arrives.

**13. Quorum**

Before formal debate or voting procedure may begin, the committee must meet quorum. Quorum for debate is defined as one-third of the members of a committee as determined by the roll call list. Before voting on substantive matters can begin, a simple majority of the members of the committee must be present. Any delegate may, at any time, request verification of quorum. The Chair will rule immediately on the motion, initiating roll call if he/she deems it necessary or if there has been a motion for such a vote from a delegate. Unless shown otherwise, quorum is assumed met.

**14. Majorities**

*Simple Majority*
A simple majority is defined as more votes in favour than opposed. Therefore, a motion fails on a tie vote. Any number of abstentions may not cause the motion to fail.

*Two-Thirds Majority*
A two-thirds majority is defined as at least two votes in favour for each vote opposed. For example, a vote of six in favour, three opposed, would pass regardless of the number of abstentions.

*Unanimous Vote*
A unanimous vote is defined as no delegate present voting against. The absence of any number of delegates or any number of abstentions shall not affect the success or failure of a motion requiring unanimity.

**15. Procedural Voting**

For procedural matters, each delegation has the obligation to vote. Only votes of "yes" or "no" shall be in order. A motion for a roll call vote on procedural matters is never in order. Procedural matters are defined as those that steer the direction of the committee, but not its substantive content.

PART V – DEBATE
**16. Agenda**

The agenda refers to the order in which the committee shall discuss the topics. The first order of business for the committee shall be consideration of the agenda. Only topics listed in the committee background guide shall be considered, except in committees designated by the Secretariat as crisis committees.

The Chair shall open a primary speakers' list and entertain a motion to set the first topic on the agenda. In the event of such a motion, the Chair shall call for two (2) speakers for and two (2) speakers against. If the motion carries, a secondary speakers' list shall be opened to discuss the agenda topic. If it fails, the committee shall continue general debate.

Once an agenda topic has been closed or tabled and all proposals concerning the topic have been voted upon, the Chair shall return to the primary speakers' list to consider the agenda again.

*Crisis Committees*
In a committee designated by the Secretariat as a crisis committee, the Dais may call upon the committee to table debate on the current topic area so that a more

urgent matter may be attended to immediately. After the crisis has been resolved, the committee will return automatically to debate on the tabled topic.

PART VI – SPEECHES

**24. Addressing the committee**

No member may address the committee without having obtained the permission of the Chair. The Chair may call a speaker to order if his or her remarks are not relevant to the subject matter under discussion. A speech may not be interrupted by another delegate, unless that delegate is rising on a Point of Personal Privilege or a Point of Order.

**25. Time Limit on Speeches**

A member of the committee may move to set a time limit on speeches. Such a motion requires a simple majority to pass. The Chair may rule such a motion out of order without appeal.

**26. Yields**

Each delegate must yield his/her time in one of the following four ways:

1) To the Chair: The remaining speaking time is forfeited and the committee moves on.
2) To comments: Two (2) delegates, selected by the Chair, may make 30-second comments on the speech just delivered. The content of comments must pertain solely to the preceding speech. The Chair shall call to order a speaker whose comment does not pertain solely to the preceding speech.
3) To another delegate: The delegate speaking may designate another delegate to speak for the remainder of his/her speaking time.
4) To questions: The delegate may use the remainder of his/her time to answer questions posed by other delegates. The Chair shall select delegates to pose questions. Only the time taken to answer the questions

shall be counted against the speaker's remaining time. The time taken to pose the questions is not taken into account, although the Chair may cut off a delegate who takes too long to ask a question.

Yields may be declared at any time during a delegate's speech. If a delegate fails to specify how he/she wishes to yield, it shall be assumed that the delegate has yielded to whichever yield has been designated as the default yield. Unless the default yield is changed, it is to comments. The committee may, by motion approved by two-thirds (2/3) majority, choose to assume any of the other three yields as a default. Delegates may not set the default yield to another delegate. All yields other than to the Chair shall be out of order while in the Primary Speakers' List.

**27. Right of Reply**

In the event that a delegate personally insults another delegate or his/her state during a speech, the insulted delegate may request a Right of Reply from the Chair. The Chair may rule such a motion out of order at his/her discretion. If a request for a Right of Reply is granted, the insulted delegate has 30 seconds to reply to the insult. A Right of Reply in response to another Right of Reply is never in order. A Right of Reply is only in order immediately following the speech in which the delegate was insulted. No decision by the Chair regarding a Right of Reply can be appealed.

PART VII – PARLIAMENTARY POINTS

**28. Point of Personal Privilege**

A delegate may rise to a Point of Personal Privilege during the discussion of any matter when his or her ability to participate in the proceedings is in any way impaired. The Dais shall attempt to remove the cause of the impairment. This point may interrupt a speaker.

**29. Point of Order**

A delegate may rise to a Point of Order to complain of improper parliamentary procedure. The Chair will immediately rule on the Point of Order. He or she shall rule out of order any points which he or she finds dilatory or improper; such a decision is not subject to appeal. A Point of Order may interrupt a speaker.

**30. Point of Parliamentary Inquiry**

A delegate may rise to a Point of Parliamentary Inquiry in the case that he or she has a question for the Dais regarding the rules of procedure. Points of Parliamentary Inquiry can neither interrupt a speaker nor be in regard to substantive matters.

PART VIII – SUBSTANTIVE MATTERS

**31. Working Papers**

Working papers are informal documents used to communicate ideas with the committee. They do not need to be in resolution format and need neither sponsors nor signatories. In order to be photocopied and distributed to the committee, working papers require the authorization of a member of the Dais. Authorization is granted on the basis of the relevance to the committee, clarity, usefulness, and originality of the paper — it should not duplicate a working paper or draft resolution already on the floor. Working papers need not be introduced and are never voted upon.

**32. Resolutions**

*Draft Resolutions*

Documents submitted to and approved by the Dais in proper resolution format will be considered and referred to as draft resolutions. The term “resolution” is to be used only in reference to documents already passed by that body or other UN bodies.

*Format*

Draft resolutions must be written in proper resolution format, as outlined in the SSUNS Delegate Handbook. Copying, distribution, and introduction of draft resolutions will occur upon approval of the draft resolution by the Dais.

**33. Introduction**

At any time following the approval of a draft resolution by the Dais, a delegate may move to introduce the draft resolution or an amendment. Adoption of this motion shall be at the Chair's discretion and shall not interrupt a speech. After its approval by the Dais and distribution to members of the body, sponsors will be invited by the Chair to read the operative clauses of the draft resolution or amendment to the body.

**34. Question and Answer Period**

Immediately following the introduction of a draft resolution, any delegate other than a sponsor of the draft resolution may move for a question and answer period. When making the motion, the delegate shall specify a length for the question and answer period. The Chair may accept or refuse this motion at his or her discretion. The motion passes on a simple majority. Once the period has begun, delegates recognized by the Chair may ask questions to the sponsors of the draft resolution.

Questions must pertain only to the draft resolution and the Chair shall call to order any delegate who does not respect this rule. Once the question has been posed, one sponsor may respond to the question within the allotted speaking time. No more than one sponsor may answer any one question. This pattern shall continue until the time allotted for the question and answer period has elapsed or no more delegates wish to ask questions. Only the time taken to answer the questions shall be counted against the length of the question and answer period.

**35. Competence of Body**

A motion to question the competence of a body calls into question the ability of a body to make recommendations or call for actions listed in a draft resolution. This motion is in order only if made immediately following the introduction of the draft resolution or amendment. The motion requires one speaker in favour and one opposed and requires a two-thirds (2/3) majority to pass. If the motion passes, the document will be withdrawn from the committee and cannot be reintroduced.

**36. Amendments**

*Non-substantive*
Amendments to draft resolutions to correct errors in spelling or format are considered non-substantive and shall be incorporated as part of the original draft resolution without a vote. Final decisions on non-substantive amendments will be made by the Dais.

*Friendly*
Substantive amendments approved by all sponsors of the draft resolution and approved by the Dais are considered friendly and are added to the draft resolution without a vote. Friendly amendments may be further amended through the unfriendly amendment process. Upon incorporation into the draft resolution, friendly amendments should be read aloud to the body.

*Unfriendly*
Substantive amendments not receiving approval from all sponsors of the draft resolution are considered unfriendly and require signatures from one-fifth (1/5) of the total members of the committee, as determined by the Dais, and the approval of the Dais to be introduced. Unfriendly amendments are read aloud and voted on separately upon closure of debate. Amendments to unfriendly amendments are out of order.

Substantive amendments to preambles are never in order.

**37. Withdrawal of Documents**

*Draft Resolutions and Friendly Amendments*
A draft resolution or a friendly amendment may be withdrawn from the consideration of the committee if all the sponsors so desire.

*Unfriendly Amendments*
An unfriendly amendment may be withdrawn from the consideration of the committee if all the sponsors of the amendment so desire.

*Reintroduction*
Withdrawn draft resolutions and amendments may be reintroduced by obtaining the signatures of one-fifth (1/5) of the members of the committee, as determined by the Dais. Such draft resolutions and amendments will be voted on following closure of debate.

PART IX – VOTING
**38. Voting Procedure**

Voting on draft resolutions, except where otherwise provided, shall occur by placard vote. Draft resolutions, except where otherwise provided, shall require a simple majority to pass and shall be voted upon as a whole.

Once a Secondary Speakers' List is exhausted or a motion for closure of debate is passed, the committee moves into voting procedure. Once voting procedure has begun, the doors of the committee room must be secured and no one allowed in or out of the room except in case of emergency. Delegates having left the room during voting procedure for any reason may not return until voting procedure has finished. During voting procedure, no note-passing or informal caucusing is allowed.

Once in voting procedure, when there are no points or motions on the floor, the Chair shall put the unfriendly amendments, draft resolutions, or parts thereof, to a vote. There shall be no further debate except as specifically provided in these rules. Once voting on draft resolutions has finished, the Chair shall declare the end of voting procedure, and the committee shall return to the primary speakers'

list. If all topics on the agenda have been exhausted, the Chair may entertain a motion to adjourn.

**39. Method of Voting**

Each member shall have one vote. All matters shall be voted upon by a show of placards. Delegates must vote “for,” “against,” or “abstain” (where applicable). No member may cast a vote on behalf of another member. During placard votes, voting with rights is considered out of order.

*Roll Call Vote*
A motion may be made to have a Roll Call Vote only on a substantive matter. This motion is subject to the approval of the Chair; such a decision is not subject to appeal. The roll call shall be done alphabetically. In the case of a Roll Call Vote, delegates may vote “with rights” upon the discretion of the Chair.

Delegates voting “with rights” shall be given a brief opportunity to explain their vote to the body upon the conclusion of voting, but before the results of the vote have been announced to the body. The chair may limit the time allotted for such an explanation.

*Pass*
During a Roll Call Vote, a member may pass, in which case he or she is placed at the end of the voting roll. Members who pass during the first sequence of voting cannot pass a second time and cannot abstain.

**40. Important Question**

A motion to have a draft resolution considered an Important Question will be ruled out of order unless the draft resolution deals with:

I. Maintenance of international peace and security.
II. Admission of new members to the United Nations.
III. Suspension of the rights and privileges of membership.

IV. Expulsion of members.
V. Operation of the trusteeship system, or
VI. Budgetary questions.

Such a motion is debatable to the extent of one (1) speaker for and one (1) against and requires a simple majority to pass. If this motion passes, the decision on the draft resolution will require a two-thirds (2/3) majority of members in order to become a resolution. Motions to designate a draft resolution an Important Question will be out of order in all Specialized Agencies.

**41. Voting on Amendments**

If an unfriendly amendment has been moved to a draft resolution, the amendment shall be voted on prior to voting on the draft resolution. If two (2) or more amendments have been made to the draft resolution, the committee shall vote on the amendments in the chronological order of their introduction to the body. A simple majority is required to adopt an amendment; a tie will result in the failure of the amendment. Where the adoption of one (1) amendment necessarily implies the rejection of another, the latter shall not be voted upon. Following the adoption or rejection of all amendments, the draft resolution in its resulting form shall be put to a vote.

**42. Division of the Question**

A member may move to vote on the operative clauses of the draft resolution individually or in groups. This motion is only in order immediately preceding a vote on the draft resolution (after any amendments have been incorporated) and is subject to the Chair's discretion. Motions to divide preambulatory clauses will be ruled out of order.

*Specifying Division of the Question*
A delegate moving to divide the question must specify a method for dividing the draft resolution. Delegates may divide the draft resolution how they see fit,

whether that is clause-by-clause, line-by-line, in groupings of clauses, or by any other combination.

*Voting to Divide the Question*
If there is more than one (1) proposal to divide the question, the motions shall be voted on in order of the most destructive to the least destructive to the spirit of the draft resolution, as determined by the Chair. The Chair may entertain as many motions to Divide the Question as he or she sees fit. Each motion to divide the question is debatable to the extent of two (2) speakers in favour and two (2) opposed. A simple majority is required to pass a motion for division of the question.

*Voting on the Divisions of the Question*
If a motion to Divide the Question passes, all other pending motions to Divide the Question are ruled out of order. The divisions indicated in a successful motion are put to an immediate vote; only those that pass are incorporated into the draft resolution. A simple majority is required to pass each division. Provided some of the operative divisions pass, the full draft resolution is then voted upon as it stands following voting on all individual sections. If all operative clauses are voted upon and fail, the entire draft resolution is considered to have failed. Moreover all preambulatory clauses remain across all new divisions.

*Division in Directive Based Committees*
All clauses within a directive will be treated as operative clauses. Moreover delegates may also divide by page, by topic, mentioning a phrase or by any other combination that they see fit.